the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE)-Main for engineering, the Common University Entrance Test (CUET) for entry into central universities and the Common Management Admission Test (CMAT) for management colleges. The NTA conducts 15 entrance and fellowship exams in a year, making it the second-largest exam-conducting body in the world, after China's Gaokao. In 2023, there were more than 12.3 million applications for the various exams NTA conducts, a measure of the vast scale of its mandate.

The recent controversies have called this very massive mandate into question, casting doubts over the agency's ability to fulfil it effectively. It may have even triggered a domino effect, as the Union ministry of health postponed the NEET-PG entrance examination conducted by the National Board of Examination, set up in 1975 to standardise postgraduate medical education and examination in India. As for the NTA, it never managed a fully pristine score in its conduct of exams. In its very first year, NEET-UG had to be rescheduled for some candidates in Karnataka over allegations of a paper leak. Glitches have occurred ever since in both medical and engineering entrance examinations almost every year (see *Glitches in NTA* in accompanying graphic).

**Compared to a million seats in engineering colleges, there are only over 100,000 medical seats, making the competition more intense**

It was certainly a poor start for the new BJP-led government at the Centre, as students took to the streets and social media to voice their dissatisfaction with how NEET was conducted and the NTA's failure. Several petitions have been filed in the Supreme Court seeking a cancellation of NEET and critics have demanded a complete overhaul of the NTA.

As Parliament convened for its first session after the general election, Opposition parties, too, seized on the controversy to target the government, accusing it of mismanagement and demanding accountability. Though initially reluctant to accept the allegations of a paper leak in NEET, which surfaced in an investigation and subsequent report of the Economic Offences Unit (EOU) of the Bihar Police, the Centre gave in to the avalanche of protests and ordered a CBI probe. While Union minister of education Dharmendra Pradhan took moral responsibility for the fiasco, he ruled out a cancellation of NEET, saying he cannot jeopardise the careers of lakhs of students who had cleared the exam rightfully because of "isolated incidents of malpractices". "When it comes to entrance tests," he told INDIA TODAY (*see accompanying interview*), "there is no shortcut, we need to make things hundred per cent foolproof. Looking into that, we have formed a very



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## What is the National Testing Agency?

**The National Testing Agency (NTA), established in 2017 by the ministry of education, conducts about 15 entrance and fellowship examinations. In 2023, 12.3 million students registered for various examinations conducted by the NTA, making it the second-largest exam-conducting agency in the world after China's Gaokao, which saw 12.9 million registrations last year**

## Structure of NTA

**The NTA is managed by a governing body that consists of a chairperson, a member secretary (director general), and eight members. The current chairperson is Professor Pradeep Kumar Joshi, former chairman of the Union Public Service Commission. Subodh Kumar Singh, an IAS officer, who was the incumbent director general during the current NEET-UG controversy, has been replaced by Pradeep Singh Kharola, another IAS officer**





